



very top, it won't be easy for any shooter to get the exposure they need to gauge the level of international competition and develop some consistency there. That's something we will need to figure out," she says.

Rana concurs that it may indeed be more difficult for India's Olympic medallists to ensure their names feature in the squad for the 2028 Games. "Winning an Olympic medal is hard, but it's even harder to win two. No one has done it in shooting, and only a few Indians have medalled twice in an individual sport. Suddenly, there are many more demands placed on you. What matters is whether you have the

hunger to stay focused," he states.

For now, Deshpande, who coaches Swapnil Kusale, and Rana feel their shooters' hunger has not diminished. "At least in Manu's case, she genuinely enjoys shooting. She has no option but to participate in many events because that's what you have to do as an Olympic medallist, but she's started to return to training. That hunger hasn't gone anywhere," he asserts. The same is true for Kusale.

"He started training a few days ago. He's happy he has the medal, but he knows he didn't shoot nearly as well as he should have in the final. He keeps revisiting some of the bad shots he made. That shows he's not

Heartbreaking moment: Arjun Babuta finished fourth in the men's air rifle Paris Olympics final after being in medal contention throughout.

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satisfied with his performance," Deshpande notes.

While the medal winners may be motivated by the possibility of doing better, those who missed out — both in making the team and during the Games themselves — find ample inspiration as well.

Naruka, however, adds that while he is driven by the desire to perform at the Olympics, he cannot focus solely on the end point of the Olympic cycle. "I think one of the mistakes I made during this Olympic cycle was concentrating only on that. I think I got a little burnt out just before the Olympics after the selection trials. I believe it's important to pace myself a little more," he reflects.

Vivaan Kapoor, who won a silver in the men's trap event at the ISSF World Cup Final in New Delhi, agrees. "I think it's important to set smaller goals leading up to the Olympics. Rather than solely focusing on the Olympics, it's crucial to check off smaller milestones like the Asian Games," says Kapoor, whose Olympic ambitions were cut short after a knee injury last year.

This approach may be particularly beneficial for younger shooters. Deshpande gives the example of Arjun Babuta, who suffered a heartbreaking fourth-place finish in the men's 10m air rifle competition in Châteauroux. "Arjun is still very young. The Olympics has been the most important competition of his career thus far. He hadn't previously competed at the Asian Games or World Championships. I believe he would have been much more composed at the Olympics had he had the opportunity to shoot at another major competition.

"This will be critical for some of these youngsters. It's essential they remain motivated. Four years may seem like a long time, but you won't even realise when it's over," she concludes.